

# EUROPE



THE SECOND SMALLEST of all the continents, Europe nevertheless has the third largest population after Asia and Africa. Rich, fertile soils, a variable but hospitable climate, and abundant natural resources have made it easy for people to live in Europe for thousands of years, establishing more than 40 nations and much wealth. Shifting land borders and inhabitants of wide ethnic diversity have caused conflict, but Europe is politically stable and is a major world power.

## Physical features

Europe's landscapes range from frozen tundra and coniferous forests in the north to the balmy Mediterranean coast and arid semi-desert of central Spain. The high mountains of the Pyrenees, Alps, Carpathians, and Urals give way to the low-lying North European Plain. Rivers provide communication and transport.

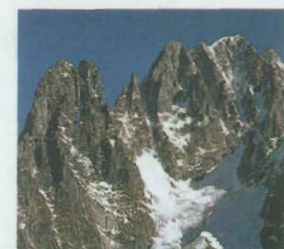
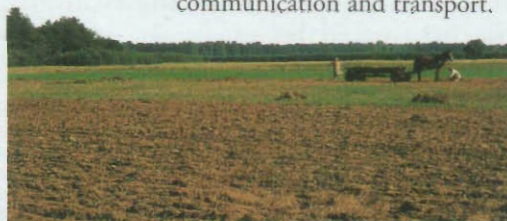


### Ural Mountains

The Ural Mountains in Russia separate Europe from Asia. They stretch 2,400 km (1,500 miles) from the Arctic Ocean to the Caspian Sea. The highest mountain is Narodnaya at 1,894 m (6,214 ft).

### North European Plain

The vast, rolling North European Plain extends from southern England, across France and Germany, and into Russia as far as the Urals. Rich in coal, oil, natural gas, and fertile farmland, this is Europe's most densely populated area.

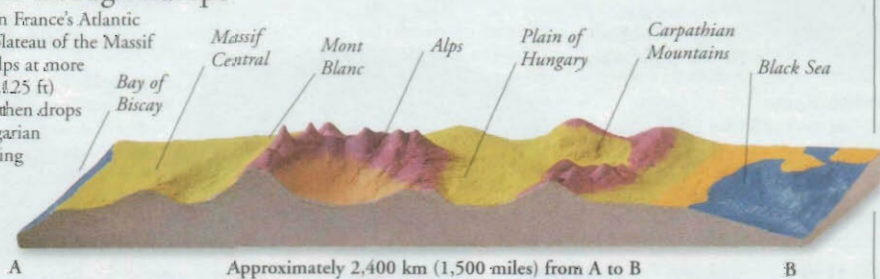


### Alps

The high Alps dominate western Europe. Stretching 1,500 km (932 miles) from southern France, through Switzerland, Germany, Italy, Austria, and Southeast Europe, this vast arc of mountains separates northern Europe from the warmer south. The highest point is Mont Blanc in France at 4,808 m (15,774 ft).

## Cross-section through Europe

Fertile farmland on France's Atlantic coast rises to the plateau of the Massif Central and the Alps at more than 4,000 m (13,125 ft) above sea-level. It then drops down to the Hungarian plain before climbing upwards again to the Carpathians and down into the Black Sea.



## EUROPE FACTS

|                         |                                                       |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| AREA                    | 10,400,000 sq km (4,000,000 sq miles)                 |
| POPULATION              | 704,900,000                                           |
| NUMBER OF COUNTRIES     | 43                                                    |
| BIGGEST COUNTRY         | Russian Federation                                    |
| SMALLEST COUNTRY        | Vatican City                                          |
| HIGHEST POINT           | Mt. El'brus 5,633 m (18,481 ft), Caucasus Mountains   |
| LOWEST POINT            | Volga Delta 28 m (92 ft) below sea-level, Caspian Sea |
| LONGEST RIVER           | Volga                                                 |
| BIGGEST FRESHWATER LAKE | Lake Ladoga                                           |